

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the first time on 21 October 2022.

The Working Group was convened by the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Murray Watt, following agreement to establish a tripartite working group at the Jobs and Skills Summit in early September.

Members of the Working Group, comprising representatives from agriculture employer groups, unions and government, welcomed the opportunity to work in a more cooperative manner to address short and long-term workforce issues in the agricultural supply chain. Several members noted they had never previously been brought together to collectively work through these issues.

Members acknowledged the importance of promoting agriculture as a career of choice for Australians. Members also noted the need to address longstanding, current and future workforce challenges in agriculture and its processing including the need to address serious skill and labour shortages, ensure the right of workers to good pay and working conditions, and deliver agricultural skills and training programs to uplift capability for workers and employers, including in the regions.

Members also welcomed the Australian Government's new commitment that agriculture is one of the priority areas in the Australian Government's fee-free TAFE initiative currently under negotiation with States and Territories. This is expected to mean more fee-free agriculture VET places will be available to students from January 2023.

Members discussed the current state of Australian agriculture and its workforce, including receiving a presentation from Dr Jared Greenville, Executive Director of Australian Bureau of Agricultural and Resource Economics and Sciences (ABARES). Key points from the presentation were the impact of COVID-19 on the supply of workers from overseas, the skill mix of the agricultural workforce, and the recent increase in workers under the Pacific Australia Labour Mobility program and the holiday worker scheme.

Members received a briefing from John Azarias on the National Agricultural Workforce Strategy: learning to excel and lessons for the future and agreed it was a good foundation to work from.

Members also endorsed a Terms of Reference and Workplan for the forthcoming twelve months, with a focus on pursuing solutions to better attract, skill, protect and retain workers in the agriculture and processing sectors.

The Working Group will next meet on 15 November 2022. Members agreed that issues relating to skills and training and migration will be considered at the next Working Group meeting.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Scott Connolly, Assistant Secretary, The Australian Council of Trade Unions
- Tony Mahar, CEO, National Farmers' Federation

- Dan Walton, National Secretary, Australian Workers' Union
- Patrick Hutchinson, CEO, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Jannette Armstrong, Executive Director - Farms, United Workers Union
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, NFF Horticulture Council
- Andrew Metcalfe AO, Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-october-2022>